Aisling centre

Hope Healing Growth

Annual Report

2020 – 2021



The Queen's Award for Voluntary Service

Congratulations to all our amazing volunteers

www.theaislingcentre.com

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The Aisling Centre

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Sr. Edel Bannon

APPOINTED LIFETIME HONORARY MEMBER

As a founding member of Aisling Centre, Sr Edel Bannon worked in the Centre for many years helping shape its mission and ethos. She served on the Board of Directors for more than a decade and, as a member of the fund-raising sub-committee since it was established in 2012. Over the past 30-years she has been a steadfast supporter of the Centre; mentor to Aisling Centre staff and a willing friend and confidant to her fellow Directors.

Sr Edel has extensive experience and wisdom in matters of good governance and management, tempered with compassion and care for both staff and clients of Aisling Centre. She conducts herself with poise and grace and embraces the core values of Aisling Centre, respect, empathy and inclusivity.

In recognition of her exemplary record and dedication to her vocation as a Sister of Mercy, her work as a Teacher and, as a founding member and Director of Aisling Centre, the Board of Directors of Aisling Centre were delighted to confer on her an honorary lifetime membership of Aisling Centre.

Accepting the nomination Sr Edel said, *"It is a rare honour to become a Lifetime Honorary Member of the Aisling Centre. On a personal level, I feel unworthy but I am very happy to receive it on behalf of the Sisters of Mercy who initially supported the project with both personnel and finance". She added that she was also "delighted to receive it on behalf of her fellow founding members Sr Mary Daly and the late Sr Helena Hunt".*



Chairperson's Foreword



I am delighted to present my first annual report as Chairperson of Aisling Centre. It is an absolute honour and privilege to be appointed into this role after many years of service on the Board. I am very aware that I have taken over from our very able Chairperson, Dr Ann McDermott, and hope to continue on with her excellent leadership and projects. It will also be a pleasure to work alongside our newly appointed Vice-Chairperson Roberta Hamilton.

Responding to the global Covid-19 pandemic has influenced every aspect of our work and the services we provide for the community over the past year. For the first time in its 30 year history Aisling Centre had to close its front door for a short time. Despite this, thanks to our dedicated team, supportive funders and courageous clients, we never stopped providing counselling for those in distress and seeking help and support.

"The Covid-19 pandemic broke out during our sessions and we transitioned seamlessly to virtual counselling. I barely noticed the difference. On completion of my sessions my mental health is in a better place and I feel I can tackle life's problems now with more tools and resilience. I am extremely grateful for the Aisling Centre".

As always we are indebted to the local community in a year when their financial support was never more needed, thank you, we couldn't have done it without you. Thank you also to all our funders. Your willingness to work with us as we navigated the transition to remote working was a real boost in a time of difficulty.

We worked hard to maintain a consistent and positive approach providing assurances and support to the community through our therapeutic services, telephone and on-line support, social and local media platforms. We also put our fledgling confidence in virtual working to good use with a 'live' programme of virtual workshops and talks supporting suicide prevention, good mental health and encouraging self-care.

Covid mitigations were also difficult for staff but, despite challenges in their individual and home circumstances, they embraced this new way of working; a massive thanks to all especially the administrative staff who continued to work in the Centre on a rotational basis providing the bedrock which kept all the working going.

In a year where uncertainty was never as prevalent, I would like to pay tribute to Centre Co-ordinator Bridie Sweeney and Clinical Co-ordinator John Bennett for their commitment, organisational efforts and care for staff and clients alike. You both worked tirelessly to ensure that all bases were covered. We thank you both for that.

I would also like to pay tribute to Mary Carroll a very valued member of the counselling team who retired in March. Mary had been part of the team for over 20 years and in that time has seen many changes. Mary is well known in the community and over the years has provided much help and support to clients and work colleagues alike. A massive thank you to Mary for her years of dedication and service. She will be sorely missed and we all wish her well for the future.

My first official duty as newly appointed Chairperson at the AGM in October was to formally accept the retirement notice of three long standing and valued board members, Sr Edel Bannon, Sr Mary deLacy and a former chairperson Pat Cassidy. All three gave many years of voluntary service to Aisling Centre and their experience/skills will be greatly missed by all. I would like to thank them most sincerely for all their hard work and commitment over the years.

At this same meeting, it was my greatest privilege to be part of conferring an 'Honorary Lifetime Membership' of Aisling Centre on Sister Edel Bannon. This one-off award was made in recognition of Edel's work as a founding member and life-long supporter of Aisling Centre.

The year also brought a very special milestone in Aisling Centre's history with the presentation of the Queen's Award for Voluntary Service. We are very appreciative to Mrs Maureen McKeever who nominated Aisling Centre for this prestigious award. It was significant that the Award Ceremony took place on the 11th November, exactly 30 years to the date that Aisling Centre first opened its doors to the community. It was with much honour and great pride that I received this award on behalf of all Aisling Centre volunteers from Her Majesty's Lord Lieutenant The Viscount Brookeborough KG. Aisling Centre could not function without the outstanding contribution and commitment of volunteers; congratulations and thank you one and all. Thanks also to FODC who illuminated the Castle in blue to mark this auspicious occasion.

Our 4th annual Hope, Healing and Growth Event was held for the first time as a digital event on Saturday 9th January 2021. This was an overwhelming success with 1,000+ people tuning in from their sitting rooms and whilst it was a free event, £6,000 was raised in donations for the ongoing work at Aisling Centre. Huge thanks to my fellow Director Aideen McGinley and her team of volunteers for all their hard work beforehand and to the inspiring speakers who gave of their time freely.

A busy throughput has meant it was time for some refurbishment at Aisling Centre and no better time when footfall was low and funding available. Absolute credit to Patricia and team for sourcing and organising various tradesmen to bring the building up to a high standard with necessary COVID-19 mitigations in place. It was very uplifting for clients and staff alike to return to a refreshed interior adorned with beautiful works of art and photography … great work everyone.

I would also like to pay tribute to my fellow Directors, for their ongoing commitment and support as we progressed over the last year. As a Board we also began meeting using Zoom with varying levels of technical familiarity, but nonetheless the work was done as we all embraced a new way of working.

Progress often requires change and within the parameters of 'Succession Planning' which had been initiated by my predecessor the Board reviewed our structures and policies. It was a very exciting time for the Board as we evaluated the needs of Aisling Centre for the years ahead and worked towards the acquisition of new Directors. This work will be ongoing and responsive to the changing needs of clients in a post-covid world.

As we emerge from the pandemic we have a greater understanding of how valuable good mental health is for us all. At Aisling Centre we are working towards further increasing our counselling capacity and build on our education and well-being elements of our work in our continued quest for Hope, Healing and Growth for everyone who crosses our threshold.

It's a privilege to be associated with the ongoing work at the Aisling Centre and I look forward to the year ahead.

Alison

Reports

CENTRE CO-ORDINATOR



The year ended as it begun in the midst of the global pandemic, the impact of Covid-19 and social isolation on our mental health making it one of the most challenging years in many of our lifetimes.

Despite these challenges it was in many ways a rewarding year for Aisling Centre. At a time when many found themselves cut off from their usual support networks, Aisling Centre remained a constant, providing a safe, online space for counselling, social interaction and support. Feedback from clients has been overwhelmingly positive with the new way of working which enabled us to reach out to the local community and beyond in a way that exceed all expectations.

"I was pleasantly surprised how well it went, I thought it would be very strange on the phone but it was very good"

It has been a busy and sometimes challenging year. Our team at Aisling Centre were not immune to the pressures and stresses caused by COVID-19. And while we, as a management team, did everything we could to support them it has to be said that their compassionate and caring work of the past year is a testament to their resilience and their commitment to the community we serve. Truly inspiring, as is the genuine care and support shown to each other.

I would particularly like to acknowledge my colleague John Bennett for his unfailing support throughout a difficult year; also, for the support given to our counselling team, as they managed the transition to virtual working. A special word of thanks to the admin team who, as always, worked quietly behind the scenes supporting the rest of the team.

Finally I would like to thank Chairperson, Alison Annan and the Board of Directors. From that first emergency pre-lockdown meeting they rose to the challenge presented and were committed to finding new ways of delivering services while ensuring the well-being and safety of clients and the Aisling Centre team.

Also huge congratulations to our volunteers on receiving the Queen's Award for Voluntary Service, well deserved recognition for their contribution to the work of Aisling Centre over the past 30 years. And, of course, the conferring of Sr Edel Bannon, founding member with a Lifetime Honorary Membership of Aisling Centre was another special moment.

I would also like to put on record my appreciation of our funders and supporters in the community who have enabled Aisling Centre to adapt and grow over the past year, as Alison says in her report *"we couldn't have done it without you!"*

As society tentatively begins to re-open we need to remember that our mental health is precious; it deserves the same care and attention as our physical health. At Aisling Centre we are honoured to play our role in promoting good mental health whether that be in the privacy of individual counselling sessions or through the well-being work we do.

We look forward to continuing to provide that support as the community begins the journey of healing in the aftermath of Covid-19. When you are ready to talk we at Aisling Centre will be here to listen.

Bridie

CLINICAL CO-ORDINATOR



Being aware of catastrophes and disaster is nothing new for any of us. We have always been familiar with watching reports of volcanos, famine, earthquakes, tsunamis and other devastating events. Through television, radio and social media we have listened to the reports and witnessed images of destruction almost as they have happened. Usually these have been in faraway places and so for most of us we have participated from a distance and a place of safety from where, when it has all become too much we have been able to return to our 'normal' lives simply by changing the channel or switching down the volume. And we will have had some comfort in knowing that skilled people, disaster relief agencies and world governments would act to sort the problems.

Our pandemic has not allowed us the same comforts. This time, in every corner of the world as in every corner of our County, we have all been drawn into the disaster. Living within it, being part of the event, every one of us has been impacted by it and every one of us is affected by it - in so many ways although to hugely varying degrees, but no one has escaped. We can have some pride that whether through caring for the sick in hospital, maintaining the weekly bin collection, looking in on isolated neighbours or simply by staying at home when required we have all played some part in lessening the damage even when as often it has been at significant personal cost.

Here in the Aisling Centre we too were suddenly forced to change and adapt the way we work in order to be able to continue to deliver our counselling and psychotherapy service to those who needed professional support. We have been privileged to have been able to remain open and available without any break in our service since Covid arrived.

From the experience of world disasters, we know that initial 'emergency' responses can and do happen quickly, and here in Fermanagh we are grateful to the many who have been part of that 'emergency' response locally. However, world experiences have also shown us that recovery is a longer process that will continue for years. As yet we don't know what the true and final impact of the pandemic will be on our mental health; but recovery will need us to be a community that is willing to notice and care for those around them and to be open to the possibility that there may be some among us who today are struggling a little more than they might have.

At this stage of the pandemic journey we look forward to keeping mental health and wellbeing at the heart of the recovery agenda. We know that if we ignore emotional and mental health problems, we simply allow them to grow to become more serious problems. So please do act for yourself, family and friends and know that we in Aisling Centre are happy to remind you that we will continue to be available in a changing environment for the many who do and will struggle.

John

Services

A WORK IN PROGRESS

I could not recommend this service highly enough.

We all know life has its ups and downs. For some of us, we do not appreciate the ups when they do come along. No one could have predicted the events of the last year. But for some of us, myself included, it brought things to a head.

Mental health is all the 'In Thing'. The problem is the taboo that surrounds these two words. Lockdown had me assessing and reassessing recent events, family events and my past. The past is something that I could never let go of. Always why? Or, why me? Or, looking to blame others. Usually looking at one perspective, mine.

I had become tearful from nothing. Finding that not having a routine to adhere to, I became unstuck. I was falling apart on the inside. I finally asked for help. I was referred to Aisling Centre. Zoom became my friend. Informal, relaxed and although not in the same room, I was still face to face with my counsellor. After introductions and legislated formalities, we had connected and my healing had begun.

Each week we began from where we left off. I was given tools to help each session. It was amazing how many tears the body can produce; but this time the tears were helping. The release they gave me eased my mind because I knew why I was crying. I was guided through my thoughts gently and with understanding. I learned how to control my breathing, concentrating on the moment. This helped ease my anxiety.

Many weeks had passed and each week I became lighter and more focused. I still have my moments and I put the tools I have been given to use.

The care, comfort and understanding I received from my counsellor give me peace of mind. I could not recommend this service highly enough. I am now also seeing both sides of the story. If I fall again I know where to come for comfort and healing.

Everyone's mental health matters, always, not just now. We are a work in progress.

J

"Welcoming staff; Process was explained really well. Information was useful and available"

"Staff were very friendly. The waiting area is very peaceful and feels very safe and quiet; counselling moved online, whole experience went very well"



"Thank you so much, you are a life saver"

COUNSELLING, PSYCHOTHERAPY & PLAY THERAPY

"I would really recommend the service. I would counsel people to not be afraid to seek help from the Aisling Centre"

COVID-19 has impacted on us all; for some bringing new and stressful challenges into our lives for others adding to existing stresses and challenges. Aisling Centre priority was to do our best to keep everyone safe while continuing to deliver much needed counselling services to the local community.

Delivering a telephone/e-counselling service was unchartered territory for Aisling Centre, therapists and clients and, not without it challenges, but it has worked very well alongside a reduced in-person service.

587 people received counselling.

Source of referrals	
Self	33.5%
GP	41%
Other Health Professionals	21%
Miscl other	4.5%

ADULT COUNSELLING SERVICE

"I felt really mentally unwell before I started using Aisling Centre Services. The referral system was really easy and I had a great therapist. He met me and made me feel really welcome when all other services were closed".

JOHN

John is in his late fifties and is the main carer for an elderly relative. This is not his first time to attend Aisling Centre.

John had experienced episodes of emotional and violent abuse from a young age, ongoing to this day, at the hands of the person he currently provides care for. He was involved with the Adult Safeguarding Team but was not in immediate danger and without reporting any of the alleged abuse to the Police there was little they could offer to change the situation.

John described being in an impossible situation where his experiences were not validated by those involved but, he could not cut the emotional ties, guilt and misplaced hope of a resolution, by walking away. The situation was made worse by the fact that John's options of moving on were restricted by his financial situation and his own physical disability. John also described himself as an alcoholic and, although he hadn't drank in almost a decade, he felt the stress of the current situation was a risk to his sobriety. He reported being surrounded by alcohol use in his current circumstances.

As a result, John was very isolated. He reported feeling unsupported by other services. He also acknowledged that he had a lot of anger and that he could be quite abrasive at times. John worked on this in therapy with the growing insight that anger further isolates him from people and support services. John had tried to get external support for the person he cares for but as they refused little could be done. John felt he could not move on due to his financial situation and the potential that he wouldn't be able to maintain his car which was his independence, his escape.

John began accessing Aisling Centre for counselling and support many years previously, since stopping drinking. On previous occasions when possible, and in this instance, John was able to link in with his previous therapist, the rapport and trust already being established, allowed for greater depth in the relationship and trust in the process earlier on in the therapy. The therapist used a humanistic approach to validate John's experiences, their lived reality and to contain some of the emotions resulting from previous trauma of reported abuse and current stress.

The therapist helped John to identify practical supports for himself and the person he was caring for, also to explore what options for change John had for himself. This identified the choices he had to make and although may be not quite ready to decide John recognised that apart from misguided hope, fear of the unknown was also holding him back. Relapse prevention work was also undertaken to deal with the cravings for alcohol and to remind John of his reasons and motivation for stopping in the first place.

The greatest benefits reported by John were the real human connection with the therapist and the consistency that the counselling service at Aisling Centre provides for him. That he could re-refer himself and re-access support in the future if needed. He did not feel rejected by the Centre as he did other services. He described the counselling service as 'a life saver'.

"Rooms are comforting, calm and comfortable"

FEEDBACK

Overall Experience of the Service	Telephone/E-Counselling	In person Counselling
Excellent	72%	87.5%
Very Good	16%	0%
Good	9.5%	11%
Fair	0.5%	0%
No Ans	2%	1.5%

Support/Service Received	Telephone/E-Counselling	In person Counselling
Excellent	83.5%	95%
Very Good	0%	0%
Good	16%	5%
Fair	0.5%	0%
No Ans	0%	0%

Telephone/E-Counselling		
Levels of Distress	Before	After
High	78%	1%
Moderate	21%	28.5%
Mild	1%	56.5%
None	0%	14%
No Ans	0%	0%

In person Counselling		
Levels of Distress	Before	After
High	75%	0%
Moderate	20%	12.5%
Mild	5%	64%
None	0%	23.5%
No Ans	0%	0%

	Telephone/E-Counselling	In person Counselling
Feeling more positive about the future	93%	96.5%
Identified improvement	98.5%	95%

"It has definitely helped me free up space in my head. I have proper space in my head now to begin new things and to begin feeling that I am starting to live again as opposed to just existing in my life"

The time Aisling Centre came into my life has made a difference to me being here and not being here. Coincided with my darkest time in life, felt very safe and secure to talk"

"Really needed this at this point in my life. Just to be able to say things out loud in the safety of the four walls of the room and have someone listen has really helped me. Thank you"

JASON



Jason is student in his early twenties. Since the COVID 19 pandemic he had started feeling low in mood and was finding it difficult to get motivated, not sleeping very well along with feelings of anxiety. Over the first couple of weeks, he discussed struggling more and more with motivation and everything seemed like a *"Trudge"*. He spoke about having negative thoughts such as *"I am not good enough" "I'm going no-where", "just existing"*. Everything was becoming such an effort and he was becoming less interested in doing normal day-to-day activities. He was feeling hopeless about the future and his mood deteriorated.

When I first met Jason for assessment in April, he told me how his problems had developed over the years but that since COVID these problems had escalated. Not being able to attend college, see friends etc. was very difficult and isolating. Jason completed some questionnaires to measure the severity of his depression and he scored in the moderate – high range. I discussed the process of therapy with Jason and we agreed to meet initially for 6 sessions followed by a review.

We started to look at how these problems he was experiencing had begun.

We were able to identify areas that may require attention in therapy. We looked at the unhelpful behaviours he had been displaying over the last year which helped in making some sense of why he was feeling so low. Behaviours such as his increased dependency on alcohol, his previous use of cannabis/weed in his earlier school/college years, his relationship with his girlfriend and his parents among other various issues. After a few sessions it came to light for Jason that while no one issue in particular explained his low mood, together they prompted an evaluation of where he was in his life, which resulted in him having thoughts that he was going nowhere and not good enough.

These thoughts triggered feelings of low mood and lack of motivation. We looked at how his thoughts were affecting how he was feeling which in turn led on to the unhelpful behaviours he was acting out, which were keeping his mood low and causing him much distress. Jason was slowly beginning to have a better understanding of himself.

Together we began to evaluate his self-critical thoughts, and the impact these thoughts were having on his mood and self-esteem. We worked on his self-critical thinking and on increasing self-compassion and self-care.

This work focused on learning to identify negative and self-critical thoughts, evaluating the reliability of these thoughts and developing more sensible and helpful ways of thinking. Jason realised that he was constantly berating himself. By developing a more balanced and kinder way of thinking, he focused on what was going well in his life and his mood slowly began to improve. Also learning some new ways to managing his low mood and stressful situations with the help of some Mindfulness techniques, deep breathing exercises etc.

We looked at Jason's interests/hobbies and what he finds enjoyable and began working on increasing these in a regular way that felt manageable for him. Engaging in these and other activities resulted in much improvement in his mood.

Dependency on alcohol was identified as one of the main factors which could be adding to Jason's problems. This was discussed and he decided it might be helpful to him to seek assistance from the addiction services.

In the meantime I continued to work with Jason while he waits for a referral to addiction services.

"Prefer face to face counselling. Has been tough but have learned coping strategies and an acceptance, a sense of peace. Anxiety has decreased"

EVALUATION FEEDBACK

What worked well?

"Aisling Centre very peaceful and relaxing to come into and made very welcome"

"Glad of support, was on the verge of a breakdown at start of therapy and now doing a bit better. Trying to take a more balanced approach to life"

"I genuinely do not know where I would be right now if it hadn't been for your intervention. I really don't think I would be here. I am forever grateful"

"Can't fault it in any way, I like the way the Centre is laid out, I like the privacy and confidentiality"

"It has helped show me how far I have come and helped me to feel a level of excitement for my future"

"I have gained the insight of knowing the difference of when I'm feeling anxious, nervous or excited. I also feel more able to deal with these emotions and my emotions in general"

"It was very good to get the service in the current situation"

"I was pleasantly surprised how well it went, I thought it would be very strange on the phone but it was very good"

"Would prefer face to face, but feel this has really helped. Has supported me through a traumatic time and underlying issues which I hadn't known were there"

"It was good but I have never used a platform like this before, took a bit of getting used to, I had some technical difficulties at the start"

"Easier to talk when not face to face for me"

"I found telephone counselling discreet and I could open up more than in person, might have hesitated to be as open in person"

Areas for improvement

Overall feedback was overwhelmingly positive, one person felt that the décor of counselling rooms was a bit dated and some felt they would have liked more information prior to starting. As always we are working to respond to this feedback.

EXPERIENCE OF TELEPHONE/E-COUNSELLING

A letter to my Counsellor



Dear F

As we approach our last session, I would like to pass on my thanks to Aisling Centre for making counselling possible and to you personally for being that person to talk to just when I needed it most.

From my initial contact with Aisling Centre, which was after the full day workshop which triggered past events for me and left me in a bad place, I was listened to and supported with great care and empathy.

When I received your call to commence sessions by telephone, I did feel apprehensive with concern about how it would work with all the restrictions in place for the COVID pandemic.

Very soon I found myself at ease after our first session and was able to work through my problems each week. Some of the weeks were very challenging as I felt overwhelmed by the grief and loss in my life; how much had I suppressed and resisted or was told that I should be over it by now, or 'time is a great healer you will be grand.'

Without your help at that very dark and lonely time in my life, alone and isolated, I cannot begin to imagine how I would have been at this time, or how I could have continued to cope with what life has dealt me.

I felt listened to, able to share freely worries and grief I had suppressed for so long. When they came up, I resisted them, and they persisted even stronger to the point that made me ill and unable to cope with the day ahead.

I looked forward to every session; it was my lifeline, and my only hope. I felt safe and able to discuss everything that troubled me and tease it out as to why it is dis-empowering me, creating so much pain in my body.

I am now in a better place, for the first time can honestly say, with your help, I have been able to work through my grief and loss and other stuff that has kept me back from enjoying life as best I could for years.

I have found me again, and I know I am ok, I have done the best I could and feel I can now cope with life's ups and downs in ways I have not been able to. I am also grateful for all the good things in my life and in particular my children. I look forward to seeing them in the not-to-distant future, as I miss them so much and have done with COVID as they live away from home.

I look forward to meeting you in person some day at Aisling Centre. Once again my sincere thanks to you and everyone who helped me. **G**

EMMA



Emma was in her mid-forties when she was referred to Aisling Centre by her GP. She presented with low mood, anxiety and suicidal thoughts. Following a traumatic event in her life and the recent break up of her marriage Emma felt that life was too difficult and that it would be better for her and everyone else if she ended it all.

Initially Emma felt that there was no point in coming to counselling and could not foresee how talking about her problems would help as this would not change what had happened or how she was feeling. However, over the weeks Emma found she was able to talk about the trauma she had experienced and her marriage breakup, in a safe and non-judgemental environment where she felt heard and understood.

Emma found sessions to be emotional and tiring however each week she began to feel an improvement in her mood and a sense of weight lifting off her. She began to see things more clearly and her suicidal thoughts became less frequent.

Through sharing her experiences and talking about her feelings Emma began to understand herself and others better. Her relationships with others had improved and although things were different she began to realise that 'all was not lost', remarking that 'I can't believe how the change in me has had such a positive impact on my family'. She became more accepting of the things she could not change and focussed on the things that she could.

With the support of her therapist Emma found that she was able to look at things more logically and challenge her negative thoughts. Her anxiety had reduced remarkably and she resumed hobbies which she had previously enjoyed. In her fifth session Emma stated that she had not had a suicidal thought that week and that she was actually feeling good.

Emma's difficulties are ongoing however as therapy ended she felt better able to deal with what is going on in her life. She is better able to look at things from different perspectives. She is taking each day at a time but feels stronger and more equipped to cope with whatever the future might bring. She also knows that there is help and support available and where to find it and is awaiting a review with her GP.

GENERAL FEEDBACK

"I didn't think I would find it effective. You're better than I thought. I didn't think I would open up or speak truthfully but have generally found it very good. Worked out well for me"

"As the weeks went by, I began to feel better, and could cope better. It has been so important to be able to talk with someone who is not family or friends"

"Highly recommend it, letting go/getting free of my past and has been good. I can't thank my counsellor enough. Now I can see the good in my life. I am proud of myself"

"It was a new experience for me, one I didn't anticipate but once I felt that I needed to get some help, I had no hesitation in asking my GP for a referral, with the support of my family. It was a worthwhile experience and so good to talk. No matter what I say, I know I'm going to be listened to and not feel stupid. I know that if I felt in the future that I needed to talk, I'd have no hesitation in contacting the Aisling Centre"

"In a much better place now. I only realise now how bad things were when I started counselling - much more perspective now and better able to care for myself"

"Apprehensive at the start but once things got going I found the service very beneficial.

I wouldn't have thought this would be good for me, but it has been so safe and working with someone I trust, I've got so much out of it"

It was a great help being able to do the sessions from the privacy and comfort of my own home. I feel that the real benefits were not having to take time to travel to Enniskillen, to try and get parking, pay for parking and the stress of driving home upset.

MEETING BILLY

As a member of the travelling community it had been a big step for Billy to come to counselling and in his first session he was very upfront about his lack of faith in the process at all.

Nevertheless here he was and in recognising that there was some part of him that was willing to give it a go. I was able to see that tiny bit of hope within him.

Billy was an intelligent kind and thoughtful man who had struggled to allow this part of himself full expression. Growing up, his desire to explore different ways of being and his sexual identity had been seen as unacceptable by his family. This had led Billy to deny this part of himself and to try his hardest to be the man that he was expected to be. He had thrown himself fully into what became a successful boxing career and channelled all his anger into the boxing ring.

The death by suicide of his role model when Billy was in his 30s shattered everything for him and he had withdrawn from the world into a deep dark depression. It was his GP who had referred him to Aisling Centre.

It took time for Billy to relax into the process of therapy but by the third week he was able to really express his hopes and desires for his life going forward. Very tentatively he explored what was really important to him and separated his own values from the values that he had originally experienced.

Billy attended six sessions, at the end he said the experience had been life changing.

In reflecting on our time together we had both learnt a lot. I again learnt about the courage and power of the human spirit and the desire to become our most authentic true selves despite the constraints of life. It also reminded me of the cultural pressures and the individuals experience within marginalised communities.

Billy had experienced a place where he was welcome just as he was and within that space had done whatever he needed to make that positive change in his life.

R

PLAY THERAPY SERVICE

41 children were referred for play therapy, 23 girls and 18 boys.

"I feel a lot better, 'cause I feel just more happy"

Source of referral	
Parent	34%
GP	20%
School	24%
Other NHS	20%
C&V Organisation	2%

Main Presentations	
Bereavement	34%
Family Separation	46%
Illness	2%
Multiple Loss	10%
Transgenerational Trauma	8%

CHILD FEEDBACK

"I'm feeling good 'cause I don't have to worry about stuff anymore 'cause I was able to talk to someone about it"

"I was relieved to know how I was feeling was ok"

"The reviews helped as it helped me and mum to understand better the impact for us as a family"

PARENT FEEDBACK

"This has been a very positive experience. My son is able to express himself better and verbalise his feelings"

"Therapy concentrated on only my daughter's feelings, what was lacking was how her actions made others feel"

"My daughter still has anger issues but talks to me more about how she feels and is also able to resolve issues more easily. She will always come to me if she feels sad, to talk about it and be comforted"

"You helped rescue our family. Thank you so much."

"Parts of me feel ok but then there are parts of me that are not and I feel I really need to cry"

"Helped my child to open up and talk more"

RYAN



Ryan is a 10 year old boy who lives with his parents and siblings. He has older siblings who do not live at home, one of whom left the home amidst difficult circumstances which had impacted greatly on Ryan.

At the initial session, Ryan presented as a bubbly, talkative boy, showing a willingness to engage in therapy. He talked about many things but when his mum approached the reason for the referral, Ryan's demeanor changed, and he became visibly upset. His mum, talked about the circumstances that led to the separation of Ryan's sibling, as a result of them leaving the home. She shared her thoughts on how this has impacted on the family as a whole and the implications of this for Ryan. As she spoke, Ryan agreed with much of what was being said, sometimes adding his own view on it. He cried as he spoke, sometimes stating that it was too hard to talk about and wanting to change the subject, but he continued with an eagerness to begin his individual sessions.

At the beginning of therapy, Ryan presented as a child who on the surface spoke about his experiences quite freely. He would talk about his sibling, but I had a sense it was because he felt that's what he was required to do. However, when it came to exploring the sense of loss that has emerged for him due to this, he struggled, often withdrawing and trying to hide from the pain he appeared to be experiencing.

During the initial sessions we addressed Ryan's expectations and about his therapy process and what he felt was expected of him by others, for example, in the first couple of sessions, he would sit as if he was doing an interview, sometimes even starting with, 'So what do you want to know/ ask me about.....?' As we focused on helping Ryan to just be himself and letting go of these expectations, he became more relaxed and able to take charge of his process.

He chose playful activities within the therapy room as a way of feeling relaxed and free to express himself. His accounts of his experiences were free flowing as he did this and with these feelings of confusion, anger, sadness, pain among others began to emerge. It was at this stage that Ryan was able to face the pain brought about by his family's experience. With this came lots of questions that Ryan had, questions he hadn't spoken to his family about. So we looked at how, if in any way conveying these to his family would help and his fears around doing so.

At the first review, Ryan and I brought these thoughts and questions to his mum. During this review they both became aware of each other's fears around talking about the situation but realised the importance for both in doing so. We explored ways, going forward that would help Ryan to feel confident in expressing his thoughts and feelings, and essentially creating some security and much needed reassurance for him. After the review, Ryan voiced a huge relief at getting to this point and how it has increased his much-sought understanding.

As Ryan continued his sessions, his confidence grew in talking about his loss and how it impacts on him and his relationships with family members. He became increasingly able to voice his needs, engaging in looking at ways of helping him to cope with his feelings and to manage his relationships with family members.

A second review was then held with Ryan's mum, focusing on family relationships, the significance of this for Ryan and how Ryan can be supported with his feelings of loss and the unwanted changes within his family.

Ryan's mum told the therapist that she had concerns about how to explain 'things' to Ryan and how much, if anything she should tell him about a very complex situation. As the therapy progressed, Ryan's mum continued to grapple with this but, she began to better understand that Ryan is also living the experience and showing a need to understand, as well as cope with his family changes; there was a balance to be found between protecting her son and the rest of her family while supporting Ryan's emotional needs.

In one of Ryan's later sessions, as he reflected his time in therapy, he described his therapist as a 'hero', explaining that before he came to therapy, he never wanted to talk about his family situation but when he 'came across' her that changed. It was clear that the person-centered approach to therapy that he experienced was central to this change as he referred to the 'nice, real person' he met that spoke to him with 'a calm voice', making it easier for him to talk about his difficulties.

Well-Being & Life Learning Services

COMPLEMENTARY THERAPY

"12 out of 10! Excellent Service, gave me a boost, helped lift my mood, very professional service"

- 28 people availed of reflexology
- 61% were victims/survivors of the Troubles
- 93% completed a full programme of treatment
- 100% noted an improvement in symptoms

Main presentations
38% anxiety
38% Joint pain
26% fatigue
25% low mood
22% stress

"Fantastic, treatment lets me forget all that is going on, a safe place from the realities of life"

"I felt calmer and it got me out of the house, something for me to look forward to"

"Fantastic programme, I feel good about myself, not as anxious, sleeping longer periods"

"My aches and pains have definitely subsided but my neck pain is a lot to do with holding stress so while it's made a huge difference it's not gone away. My sleeping pattern has improved which is a benefit"



C-19 lock down and restrictions on close contact services made this a challenging time for many people and the CT therapist provided 19 people with on-going telephone support during lockdown.

"A fantastic service, helped me with my stress levels"

"It was really worthwhile, thank you"

VIRTUAL PROGRAMMES

Working virtually was well outside our comfort zone in Aisling Centre. We started out during the first lockdown with some self-care workshops in mindfulness and yoga, for our own team and groups who normally operate out of Aisling Centre. These worked very well, it also helped us realise that providing a real connection for people was more important than having perfect IT skills. So we decided to go for it.....

HOPE HASN'T BEEN CANCELLED, HOPE HEALING GROWTH 2021

The fourth Hope Healing and Growth event was held for the first time as a Virtual Day of Inspiration on Saturday 9th January. Little did we envisage last year that, 2020 would be the year where we would all have to draw heavily on the virtue of Hope. Never was this event more needed with the emergence of COVID-19 in terms of individual and community well-being as we moved forward into 2021.

As it became increasingly obvious that we wouldn't be able to hold the event in person we decided, with some trepidation, to embrace technology and go for a virtual event via ZOOM. What a learning curve!! Thanks to great teamwork, amazing co-operation from our guest speakers and some tech know how provided by Niall Bogue the event was a wonderful success.



"To all involved in preparation, getting such really wonderful and inspirational speakers, administration and the gift of technology and technical expertise, making it possible for us to join in such a wonderful day in these times, Thanks"

It was also decided that it should be a free event with donations optional in recognition of the difficult year it had been financially for many individuals, families and businesses.

Almost 1000 people tuned in to the event with some joining from as far away as America!

"Just to say well done and sincere thanks to all of you for putting together a wonderful day of Hope Healing and Growth; three generations of my family tuned in on Saturday and all were very uplifted and inspired. So good of all those involved to share their stories so honestly and openly. A lovely start to what I hope will be a brighter year for all. Please thank all involved."

The event was opened by Aisling Centre patron Adrian Dunbar followed by the ever popular Declan Coyle, back to talk about positive thinking and the 'The Green Platform' followed by Conor McCafferty who gave a powerful presentation on the impact of alcohol on our emotional health.. Lisa Strutt shared her message of the power of kindness and the importance of self-compassion. Local architect Richard Pierce shared his compelling story and his insights on challenges and acceptances encountered as he found his place as a gay man growing up in a small and essentially rural community. Noelle McAlinden, suicide prevention advocate, shared her personal story of bereavement by suicide and she highlighted the need for self-expression and self-compassion especially in challenging times.

The afternoon slot started with Irene Teague who talked about her book ,'We had to say goodbye before we even met', telling her own story of grief and loss, and the importance of grieving. Dara McAnulty inspired everyone as he shared his passion for nature and wildlife, reading extracts from his award winning book, 'Diary of a Naturalist'. The final speaker of the day, Hugo Duncan, spoke of the challenges he had faced in life, stressing the importance of positivity and also of reaching out for help.

The plenary session, ably chaired by the facilitator for the day Aideen McGinley, allowed all the speakers to come together and reinforce their message of hope. The recurring themes of taking time to breathe, take stock, listen and go forward with self-compassion and kindness for ourselves. With Dara McNichol bringing the event to a close with his songs of hope.

"I have just finished watching HHG event and I am both washed out and elated; such generous sharing of very painful stories, but what resilience and such a strong message of hope. There was such a spectrum of pain filled situations touched upon; it reinforces the need for Aisling Centre more than ever. It may be worth considering Zoom as a way to go for the future as I felt I was able to listen and to concentrate better than at live event. Less distractions. My congratulations to all involved in this uplifting event."



The speakers also got a lot from participating in the event,

"It was a very cathartic process for me to write the story down. Even though I knew all the individual pieces of information putting them all in a cohesive narrative has helped me clarify things in my mind"

"There is hope, healing and growth in telling your story at the right place and at the right time, it was a privillage to be involved in the HHG conference"

LESSONS IN HOPE - Save the date

Hope, Healing, Growth - Virtual Day of Inspiration Saturday 8th January 2022

Eileen Forrestal	The Courage to Shine – Find Your Voice and discover the healing power of your words
Jack Kavanagh	The Heartbeat of Life
Jonny McCambridge	Afraid of the Dark
Mandy Chism	The Journey of Hope following Hurt
Joe Slattery	Horses Helping People Find the Answers From Within
Melanie Grimsley	Beauty from Ashes

Song of Hope – Guest Performance
Adrian Dunbar, Patron, Aisling Centre

Booking via Eventbrite – https://bit.ly/3Bayruk

THERE IS ALWAYS HOPE

A three-month series of workshops and talks designed to support suicide prevention and promote self-compassion, reduce stress and improve overall mental health and emotional well-being, was supported by CFNI/Comic Relief. Workshop speakers and facilitators included members of Aisling Centre team and invited guests. The workshops provided a 'live' and interactive connection for people at a time when physical contact was restricted due to C-19. They also served as a reminder that there is help available.

"It is sad that we could not be together in a room but it is wonderful though that these Zoom sessions can reach out to so many people from further away, people who couldn't really travel to Fermanagh and wouldn't have been able to take part in them otherwise"

The programme offered on-going workshops in art and yoga (for children and adults) as well as mindfulness drop in sessions. Talks and workshops explored the impact of grief in the time of C-19, bereavement by suicide, and self-harm as well as the topics of stress relief, good nutrition, self-care, self-compassion and rest and renewal.

"This talk was fabulous so much information on why we need to care for ourselves and how to. My son found it very helpful, he has come back to live with us temporarily after a marital breakup and found a number of things that will be useful to him. It also opened up conversations between us and we spent a long time afterwards talking about our individual struggles during Covid and struggles with other life events"

Workshop facilitators included Conor McCafferty, Zest, Nuala Lilley, Nature's Choice, artist Hazel McCrann, Shauna, Aurora Yoga, Siobhan Conlon, Mindfulness and therapists Joni Crone, Brenda Wynne-McKervey and Sharon Fitzpatrick.

Feedback was very positive

"Thank you to the team who put the program together it has been wonderful so far to be able to access such wonderful talks from people who are so understanding and informative from the comfort of my own home"

"Thank you so much for arranging the classes which I have thoroughly enjoyed. Each class brought something new but also dwelt on the key yoga poses and practising our breathing"

"This grief workshop was very difficult for me to do however I found it very helpful. The trainer was excellent and it was delivered in a very kind and compassionate way. Very well done and thanks for follow up support"

"It was very informative on food and health. I gained some knowledge"

"This was a great introduction to inform people about the work of the Aisling Centre by The Manager and she made us feel very welcome"

"The course went well, loved the follow up of information which was sent in email. Thank you for providing really good workshops via zoom"

"The simple slides, the speaker was wonderful, so calming and thought provoking"

"I found it so engaging and so validating, I wish again to thank everyone involved"

Professionals

With hindsight we shouldn't have been surprised by the number of mental health professionals who joined the sessions, after-all they too were dealing with the impact of C-19. Many came from England and some from as far away as the USA and Canada.

"I wanted to thank you - this was a superb session, humane, compassionate, relevant, clear and informative.

Thank you so much. I am in a new post as a Suicide Bereavement support officer and this was invaluable"

"Thank you for giving insight into this area which has always been quite a taboo subject in my line of work. Very interesting to see the different avenues of how to approach grief; I am taking away some of the valuable information and ideas which I will be using for one of my complex clients"

"I just wanted to say thank you - I've really enjoyed the sessions and taken a lot from them. I've really tried to incorporate those mindful moments into my day and I feel the benefit of them. It has been really helpful for my client work too!"

539 people attended

"Great the Aisling Centre are offering these events and the fact that everyone can join without a specific cost"

A real support

"We need mindfulness more than ever. Lockdown 3 is very hard. Getting to know about my Mindfulness muscle and start working on building it up"

"Grief is very isolating and sharing experiences can be a help. I have to commend Aisling Centre for their organisational skills and the course co-ordinator was lovely"

"I loved the yoga classes, with the stresses of home schooling, working from home, it was like my "look forward to" in the week. Facilitator had a lovely calming gentle nature that just made me zone out in my own home. Would definitely recommend it to anyone"

"I have very much appreciated the sessions over the last weeks"

"I thoroughly enjoyed the mindfulness sessions & looked forward to them every week"

I didn't know how much I really needed this until today. Difficult week and so important to be reminded to look after yourself, I am not the best at this"

MY JOURNEY TO MINDFULNESS

I want to thank you so much for your company and for introducing me to the joys of "mindfulness".

I first heard of meditation while studying in college. Some years later a friend gave me the book 'Meditation' by Sogyal Rinoche, this sparked further interest.

Over ten years ago Aisling Centre was offering an 8-week MBSR mindfulness programme (Mindfulness Based Stress Reduction) facilitated by Mary Conway.



At that time I was finding some aspects of my work stressful so I booked onto the course. Those 8 weeks were an amazing journey for me. I fully committed myself to the course, getting up at 6am to practise before my drive to work. Since then mindfulness has been in my daily life giving me strength, balance and grounding.

Mindfulness has brought so much into my life that I considered learning more about the method and the possibility of teaching it. Once again opportunity came through Aisling Centre. With the support of the Mercy Fund they were offering one-off training bursaries, Mary Conway encouraged me to apply for MBSR teaching with the Centre for Mindfulness Research and Practice, Bangor University, Wales.

I taught my first MBSR programme at Aisling Centre in 2020.

During the first Lockdown I became interested in Mindfulness Self Compassion following an inspiring online talk by one of the teacher/trainers from the Centre of Mindfulness Self–Compassion. Once again I became curious and spent the last year developing my practice and undertaking training. I completed Mindful Self-Compassion Teacher Training with the Centre for Mindful Self-Compassion. I also undertook training for delivering programmes virtually.

Aisling Centre asked me to do some virtual workshops with their team to help support their well-being during the first lockdown. Getting used to the tech was fun, especially with the builders next door!

As lockdown and Covid restrictions continued, Aisling Centre asked me to deliver a series of drop in sessions to groups who work out of the Centre in addition to the public. It was a privilege and a joy to be able to support people during these challenging times.

Siobhán

MINDFULNESS FEEDBACK

"Just want to thank you for the Mindfulness, really enjoyed it very much, very relaxing. You have been a great support in lockdown."

"I really appreciated meeting each Wednesday evening and while I was only getting familiar with using chat in the last few sessions I felt it was of real benefit to me. The poems and stories were just lovely and linked so well with many aspects of our day to day lives. Thank you for leading this course."

"I've really enjoyed and benefitted from the class during these very difficult months. I loved how you guided each session, you are an inspiration for us."

"I liked the mix of poetry, breath work and meditation and the small group size worked well for discussion. The virtual session via Zoom suited me perfectly to fit in with work and home commitments and made me create a safe space at home that I can now use to practice meditation"

"Thank you for all your mindful guidance and insight - it has reignited my forgotten learning from my MBSR course! I'm making great use of all that I have learned"

THE BENEFITS OF YOGA



We have a very special day every year on the 21st June, the International Day of Yoga. International days are set by the UN as a way to educate the public on areas of concern, to mobilise political will, or in this case, to highlight and celebrate an exercise that is fast being recognised as having many benefits for its practitioners in both a mental and physical way.

So it seemed fitting to write a blog on some of the benefits of yoga and why it might be good to build yoga into your daily routine.

To start, there are different styles of yoga - Yin, Ashtanga, Vinyasa, Hatha. I practise and teach Hatha. Hatha is usually what comes to mind when you think of your typical yoga class - slow movements, led by the breath, connecting mind, body and breath. Slow movement, but slow doesn't mean you won't feel it the next day though - ask my yogis! Because there

Services

are different styles, it's important if you try one and don't enjoy it that you don't give up. Try another style, or even just a different teacher.

Once you find the right class, with regular attendance and consistent work on posture and alignment, you can really start to build strength, stamina and flexibility as you become more comfortable in the poses.

Strength - Yoga is a great way to increase strength in your body - many of the poses are designed to work simultaneously on the upper and lower body - think of the Warrior poses and how they feel when you hold them for more than a few breaths! Yoga is a great way to build upper body strength, especially for women. Women often neglect the upper body, because traditionally lifting heavy things was left to men and the idea of a woman being muscular was just not the 'done' thing! Thankfully, this is changing. I personally love doing weights and think everyone should add a bit of strength training to their routine!

Flexibility and Balance - Our modern lifestyles - sitting at desks for long periods; repetitive manual labour; sitting hunched up on the sofa when we get home from work; general stress; sports and life injuries - these all affect our flexibility as we age. Yoga gives us some of that flexibility back. It's important to realise it won't happen overnight. It can take time to heal a body that has been neglected for a long time. But we've all been there, so don't give up if you find your flexibility is taking longer to bounce back than you thought it would. With flexibility and strength comes balance; every pose is done on the right and left side of the body, so that you work each side evenly. Think of how many sports focus on one side - kicking the ball off one leg, building strength in one side of the body for rowing/boxing/martial arts, etc. Yoga gives our body some of this physical balance back and helps our hand eye co-ordination with actual balancing poses too!

Improved Posture/Improved Confidence - Unlike a gym class or team sport, yoga is just you on your mat. So stop looking around at everyone else (everyone else is too busy to be looking at you!) Start to focus on what YOU are doing. This is when you start to connect your mind to your body and the breath.

This can lead to body awareness off the mat, which stops you from holding yourself in bad postures, or thinking a little more before you slouch and correcting it. By holding your body in a way which feels good, you feel good too and this leads to improved confidence.

Mental Wellbeing through Self-Awareness and Calm - Starting and ending your yoga practice with breathing exercises and being aware of your breath throughout the class, helps you to learn to control your breath; this can help reduce stress and anxiety helping to lift your mood and improve your wellbeing. I get lots of my yogis telling me that yoga helps them relax and sleep better!

Regular Practice - There are lots of benefits to be had, but obviously they come with a caveat. You won't enjoy all of these things without a regular practice - daily or weekly. For many of us, money is the issue that stops us before we even begin, but there are many excellent free videos that you can access on the internet which has introduced millions of people to the world of yoga. I also have some free videos on my YouTube channel, Aurora Yoga Studio NI.



These are just some of the benefits of yoga for your body and mind. Every person will find a few more unique to them. And hopefully this blog will encourage some of you to take your first steps into the world of Yoga. Let me know what you think!

Shauna



YOGA FEEDBACK

"Excellent presentation helped us understand the benefits of Yoga both physically and mentally; liked the history of Yoga and learning about the many 'types' of Yoga available. Key learning point for me was if you don't enjoy this type, don't give up, try another kind of Yoga, find the kind that suits you"

"I really enjoyed the yoga. Teacher explained and demonstrated all poses very well and it was delivered very punctually every Wednesday"

"Each class brought something new but also dwelt on the key poses and practising our breathing, very much appreciated"

"I think yoga is good for children, I do yoga breathing at school, when I get mad"











Elizabeth the Second,

By the Grace of God of the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland and of Our other Realms and Territories Queen, Defender of the Faith, to

Aisling Centre

Supporting positive mental health and serving the local community since 1990.

Greeting!

We being cognisant of the said group's outstanding voluntary work in the community, and being desirous of showing Our Royal Favour do hereby confer upon it:

The Queen's Award for Voluntary Service

for voluntary service by groups in the community 2020

for such period as the group continues to provide its current service and do hereby give permission for the authorised emblem of the said Award to be displayed on the group's letterhead and other public material.

Given at Our Court of Saint James's under Our Royal Sign Manual this second day of June 2020 in the sixty-ninth year of Our Reign.

Presentation of Queen's Award for Voluntary Service By Her Majesty's Lord Lieutenant, The Viscount Brookeborough KG 11th November 2020



Above photo of Enniskillen Castle courtesy of photographer Ronan McGrade

Governance

TREASURER'S REPORT

The past year has provided many challenges to the Aisling Centre. The on-going pandemic has created a greater public awareness of positive mental health within our society. To deliver the service has been challenging but rewarding. Time and again strong adherence to high standards and quality provision has provided the foundation for a great year's work. We are so fortunate to have a dedicated staff team and a vigorous Board of Directors. Together they have charted Aisling through challenging times with the hope of better days to come.

Once again we have been fortunate to receive the support of a wide and varied range of financial supporters, without whom the Centre would not have been able to operate, particularly in this year of global pandemic. Our funding has come from the Western Health and Social Care Trust, the Victims and Survivors Service and BBC Children in Need, NRA, St John of God and Community Foundation NI (CFNI). We also received financial support from Belfast Cathedral Sit Out and Trusthouse Charitable Foundation. We were fortunate to receive Covid-19 support funds which helped ensured that we were able to continue to work throughout this pandemic, thanks to Charities Aid Foundation, CFNI, Department for Communities and Enniskillen Rotary Club. Additionally, we have been supported locally by Fermanagh and Omagh District Council through a wide range of grant aid for which we are most grateful.

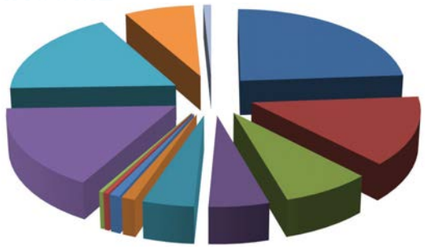
We look forward to having a continued relationship with these funders and to being able to develop relationships with new ones.

Aisling also has a very hard working and imaginative Fundraising Committee. Their sterling efforts not only brought significant funding into the Centre but also helped raise awareness of our work in the public arena. Nowhere has this been more apparent than in in our 'Hope Healing Growth Day of Inspiration' bringing people together from far and wide in a virtual seminar. We have seen at first hand the fund-raising undertaken right across the community and to witness the generosity of individuals, communities and workplaces who have given so generously throughout the year and in so many different ways. We thank everyone who has given time and effort to support our work and look forward to their continued support.

Lastly, we value the provision of accommodation to the many groups and organisations who use the Centre on a regular basis. This, on a day to day basis is the beating heart of a vibrant community hub where everyone is welcomed and no-one is turned away. The coffee shop can always provide a tasty treat delivered with a smile. It is also worth noting our indebtedness to the Sisters of Mercy for their continued support and encouragement. I commend this financial report.

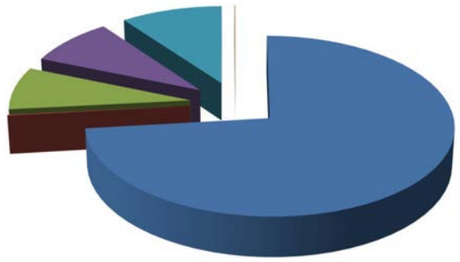
Neville

INCOME



- VSS
- WHSCT
- Covid Support Funds
- BBC Children in Need
- SJOG
- Furlough
- NRA
- FODC
- CFNI
- Miscl Small grants / contracts
- Fundraising & Donations
- Room Donations
- Programmes / Income Gererations

EXPENDITURE



- Counselling / Service Provision
- Fundraising & PR Exps
- Miscl Overheads
- Repairs & Maintenance
- Management & Admin
- Depreciation

Funder Acknowledgements

Western Health and Social Care Trust

VSS Victims & Survivors Service

BBC Children in Need

Belfast Cathedral

CAF Charities Aid Foundation

The Community Foundation Northern Ireland

Trusthouse Charitable Foundation

Saint John of God Foundation

Rotary International

Neighbourhood Renewal

Comic Relief

Fermanagh & Omagh District Council
Comhairle Ceantair Fhear Manach agus na hÓmaí

COVID-19 Charities Fund

DfC Department for Communities www.communities-ni.gov.uk

In partnership with The National Lottery Community Fund

Strategic Plan 2019-2023

VISION / DREAM

Positive Mental Health and Emotional Well-Being for All

MISSION

To provide opportunities for hope, healing and growth in a welcoming and supportive environment

COMMITMENT

Striving to meet Professional and Ethical Service Standards & Adopting an evidence-based approach within a robust outcome measurement framework

PRINCIPLES / VALUES

Confidential, Respectful, Empathic, Supportive, Non-judgemental and Inclusive of All
Working collaboratively with others to achieve shared objectives Sensitivity to Current & Emerging Needs

STRATEGIC PRIORITIES

- To promote positive mental health and emotional well-being for adults, young people and children in Co Fermanagh and the surrounding area through the provision of an accessible and professional counselling, psychotherapy and play therapy service
- To provide a range of additional activities that will enhance and complement the counselling and psychotherapy work of the Centre and give additional value to clients
- To ensure that the Aisling Centre is an effective, accountable, transparent organisation that meets the requirements of all stakeholders

It should be noted that all ideas, opinions and comments included in this report are entirely the responsibility of the report author and do not necessarily represent or reflect funder policy.

COVID-19

THE AISLING CENTRE TEAM IN LOCKDOWN

A Therapist's reflection



It is now some months since we first found ourselves in the land of *"Lockdown"*.

Yes, it really has been quite the strangest of times, and for someone who is quite a *"people person"* this whole experience has been quite challenging in many ways. Not having the freedom to meet family and friends whenever I wished was difficult at times, especially having just had a family bereavement a few weeks before the lockdown. Not being able to reminisce and grieve with those closest to me was not easy.

The technology and phone have been nonstop during this time which of course is good for keeping us connected, however I personally find it very draining and exhausting at times. Straining to listen and not see the other person is a challenge in itself. I do worry that I have become a bit of a recluse finding myself content to be at home (most of the time) and at times find it like a day's work to get myself ready to even go out to the local shop to get the few bits of groceries etc, I'm quite content with my own company and notice it has now become more of an effort to talk to people.

However going through this pandemic has given us many things to be grateful for in life and has given us all the time to slow down - to stop and smell the roses, get out of the rat race we all seem to have found ourselves in over the last number of years. We got to notice the blue skies we were so fortunate to have at the beginning of it all, hear the birds of a lovely summer's evening - the Cuckoo being my favourite, to breath in the clean fresh air which has come about because of less air travel, less cars on the road etc, to meet our neighbours who we may never had the time to meet before all this set in. Maybe giving some of us that time to ask ourselves *"what is it all about"*; what am I doing with my life and, looking at what is really important in this precious life we have been given.

I personally have found this experience has allowed me to once more prioritise my values and choose how I wish to live in the future.

The telephone and the internet have given us tools to be able to continue to offer counselling during this time. But, I do miss seeing my clients face to face, that human connection is so important for us as human beings. I look forward to the day when I can meet with people again.

Nuala

STAYING CONNECTED



"You guys without doubt provide one of the very best working environments I have ever experienced; a totally fabulous combination of efficient and nurturing."



It's so easy to go to work and feel that no matter what happens that there is a whole team of people willing and able to help. The extra touches like the yoga and our lovely picnic box on Friday make me feel very cared for in a lovely genuine way.

I am so proud to be a member of this very special staff team".

The healing power of nature

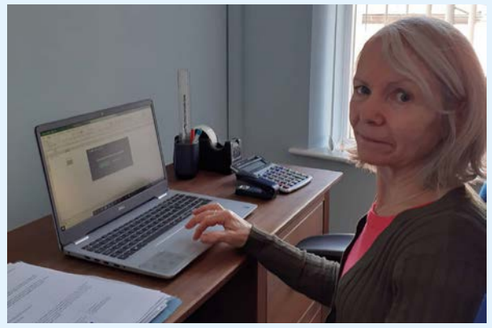
Sheila kept us all entertained and uplifted sharing the fantastic photographs she took during her daily walks. Some of these photographs now adorn the walls of Aisling Centre so that even though we are inside we can still experience and enjoy the beauty and the healing power of nature.





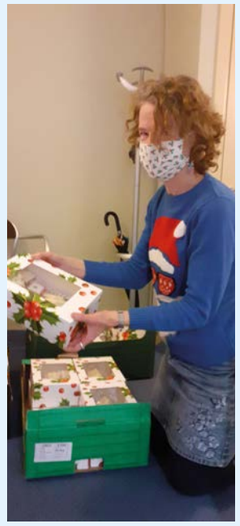


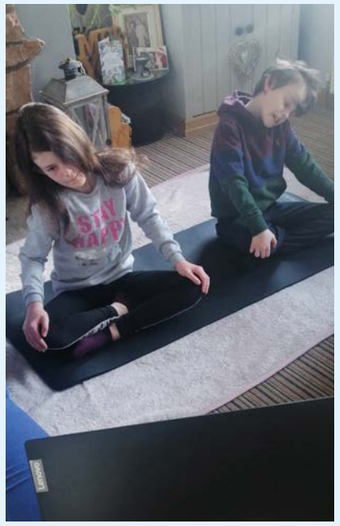














The Décor of the Building is Important



At Aisling Centre we believe that it is hope which gives people the courage to take that first difficult step across the threshold and, that the journey of healing begins once that step is taken. Therefore the décor of the building is important; it speaks to the person entering the building telling them that they are valued, welcome and safe.

Covid-19 brought with it many stresses but with fewer people in the building, it created a space for Aisling Centre to do some much needed building refurbishment. As the FODC Peace IV project completed their work on the exterior of the building, installing a new 'shop front', Facilities Manager Patricia Kelly, who enjoys a project, set to work. Possibly the most noted improvement was the updating of the toilets! A long desired project by some and well worth the wait. This was followed by painting, replacement of worn carpets and improved signage. Interactive screens have been installed in meeting rooms along with much needed new and comfortable chairs. A burst of colour and healing energy with the display of some beautiful art work, photographs and prints adds the final touches.

On her recent visit to the Centre Sr Edel Bannon, founding Sister and Lifetime Honorary Member of Aisling Centre was delighted with the refurbishments which she described as 'tasteful' and 'modern', going on to say, "The really heart-warming thing is that the beauty of the building is a mere reflection of the beauty of the work of the Aisling Centre and the hope, healing and growth it brings to so many people".

We could not have done this work without the support of some of our funders most notably VSS, who made some slippage available to us. Also, the generosity of local suppliers, most particularly, Enniskillen Carpet Centre and Jim's Paints. Local artists Marjorie Leonard, Jenny Thompson, Noelle McAlinden and Sheila Gilroy-Collins were incredibly generous with their time and talents enabling us to have some beautiful original pieces of art work hanging in the public areas of the Centre. While our own Sheila Johnston's photography which helped our team through lockdown, now brings the healing power of nature indoors for us all to enjoy.

While we look forward to welcoming everyone back to our clean, fresh and newly refurbished building we want to say a special 'thank you' to Kimga Amtomzak (from Prestige Cleaning) who keeps the building immaculate.










We are listening

Your feedback suggested that some pictures would make the Centre feel more welcoming, so Fionnuala got to work .....

"The artwork, original and of such high quality, speaks to the soul and honours the wonderful gift of creativity, which Aisling has always sought to nurture in a myriad of ways"

Sincere thanks to everyone whose wonderful generosity has enabled us to have so many beautiful pieces of work on display in the Centre.

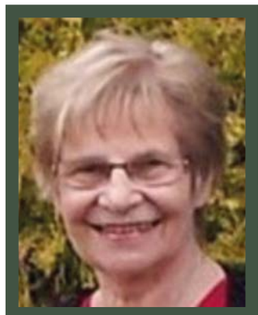






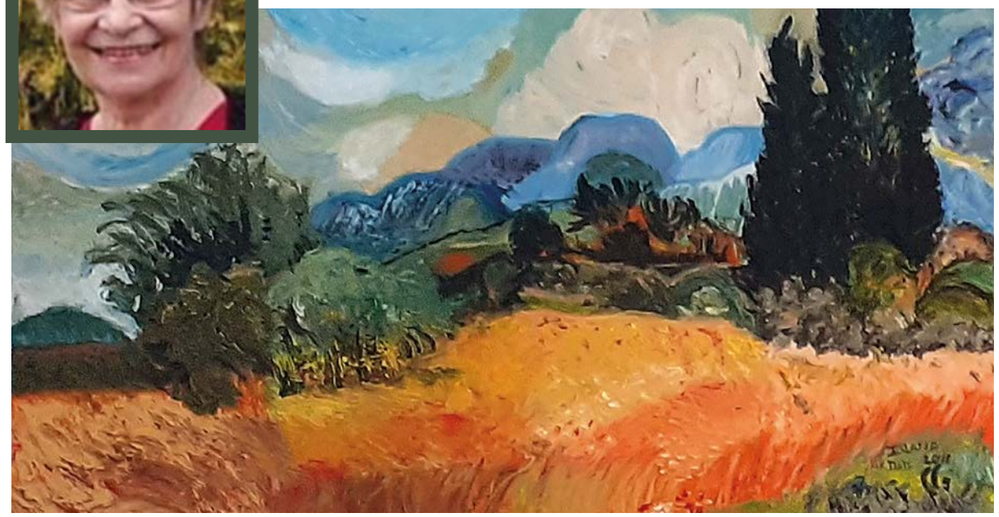




In memory of The Late Pat Illand

Wheatfield with Cypresses, after a painting by Van Gough
By Island Artists
Presented to Aisling Centre 2020



ISLAND ARTISTS

Coming together to share a love of art and painting Wednesday Afternoons
2-4pm @ Aisling Centre

New Members Welcome For information contact Paula Martin, 077 1896 6787

Westend Coffee Shop

CAFÉ & OUTSIDE CATERING
Monday – Saturday
8:00am – 5:00pm

For information contact
Barry – 028 6634 0475 / 079 79975000



"Waiting room was peaceful/relaxing, Westend Coffee Shop was nice afterwards"



Forget Me Not

Bereaved By Suicide Support Group

Meets first Monday of each month
7.30pm – 9.00pm Venue - Aisling Centre

For more information, please contact
Fidelis Simpson T. 077 4085 6416





Tree of Lights 2020

'Really meant a lot – this happening this year'

'Thank you and very much appreciated – so fitting with the situation we are all in'

'Thank you for making it happen – we appreciate time to reflect and come together to support each other.'

Thank you for the lovely service – it helped a lot with our grief.'

'We take such comfort on that day – thank you'

'Lovely way to remember our loved one'

'Something so comforting about this thank you'







Tree of Lights 2021

Sunday 28th November
Aisling Centre

Remember me in every special way, keep me close to your heart, we'll meet again one day

For more information, please contact
Fidelis Simpson, T. 077 4085 6416

In AA, everyone is equal and it's anonymous, members are known by their first name only

"Who you see here, what you hear here, let it stay here"

If you think you have a problem with drinking, we're here to help.

If you seem to be having trouble with your drinking, or if your drinking has reached the point of where it worries you, you may be interested to know something about AA (Alcoholics Anonymous).

We who are in AA came because we finally gave up trying to control our drinking. We still hated to admit that we could never drink safely. We found out that many people suffered from the same feelings of guilt, loneliness and hopelessness that we did. We found out that we had these feelings because we were sick with alcoholism.

We decided to try to face up to what alcohol had done to us. Here are some of the questions we tried to answer honestly. See how you do. Remember, there is no disgrace in facing up to the fact that you have a problem.

Answer YES or NO to the following questions

1. Have you ever decided to stop drinking for a week or so, but only lasted for a couple of days?
2. Do you wish people would mind their own business about your drinking-- stop telling you what to do?
3. Have you ever switched from one kind of drink to another in the hope that this would keep you from getting drunk?
4. Have you had to have a drink in the morning during the past year?
5. Do you envy people who can drink without getting into trouble?
6. Have you had problems connected with drinking during the past year?
7. Has your drinking caused trouble at home?
8. Do you ever try to get 'extra' drinks at a party because you do not get enough?
9. Do you tell yourself you can stop drinking any time you want to, even though you keep getting drunk when you don't mean to?
10. Have you missed days off work because of drinking?
11. Do you have blackouts?
12. Have you ever felt that your life would be better if you did not drink?

Did you answer **YES** four times or more? If so, you are probably in trouble with alcohol. Why do we say this? Because thousands of people in AA have said so for many years, they found out the truth about themselves - the hard way.

Is AA for you? Only you can decide

Does not promise to solve your problems. But we can show you how we are learning to live without booze one day at a time. We stay away from that first drink. If there is no first one, there cannot be a tenth one. When we got rid of booze, we found that life became much more manageable.

Try to keep an open mind on the subject

Determine for yourself whether or not alcohol has truly become a problem for you. And remember that you will always be most welcome to join one of the many local AA groups.

AA MEETINGS ARE HELD IN AISLING CENTRE
Meetings are open to anyone struggling with addiction.
For information t: 028 66 325811 / e: info@theaislingcentre.com

THE ESCAPISTS

Female Carers' Support Group
Meets weekly @ Aisling Centre
Wednesdays 10.30am – 1.00pm

Something For Everyone
Activities, Talks, Relaxation & More

For information contact Aisling Centre 028 66 325811

Who are we?

We are a group of female Carers, who meet weekly. Our aim is to help relieve the burden of care for the carer and promote "Me Time".

The Escapists have been running for 12+ years and we have a lovely bunch of ladies in our group. We run programmes from September till June every year with a break during the summer months.

As a group we try to offer a wide range of activities in our programme. We go golfing and bowling. We try our hand at painting and weaving. We enjoy many other crafting workshops too. We have speakers in to give motivational talks. We hold workshops on healthy eating. We enjoy some treatments e.g. reflexology, massage, waxing and even getting our nails done. We go on walks and enjoy nothing more than a spot of lunch. There's something for everyone.

During Lockdown we did run a limited programme, following social distancing until it was no longer viable to do so. The Committee members kept in touch with our ladies during this difficult time.

Everyone is welcome. If you're interested in joining our wee group, please contact Aisling Centre.



Meet The Team

STEPPING DOWN AS CHAIRPERSON



Having completed her term of office Dr Ann McDermott stepped down from her position as chairperson in October 2020. Reflecting back on her term of office Ann spoke of the exponential growth in the work of Aisling Centre. “While it may not look very different from six years ago, the serene face of Aisling hides an enormous increase in activity, generated from the year on year increase in need”.

In 2015/16 Aisling Centre was receiving an average of 37 referrals per month, with 369 clients attending for counselling that in itself being a significant increase from the previous years; today that number has more than doubled. Aisling Centre receives an average of 80 referrals a month, 801 people (adults and children) attended counselling at the Centre last year.

As she stepped down from her position as Chairperson Ann thanked her vice-chairperson Alison Annan and fellow Directors for their hard work and commitment to Aisling Centre and for the great support during her time as Chairperson. She also thanked the hard working and dedicated team of staff and volunteers. “It has been a great honour to serve as Chairperson of this wonderful organisation and I look forward to continuing to serve as a member of the Board of Directors”.

Directors and staff paid tributes to Ann’s capable and steady hand as Chairperson. With her quiet, unobtrusive, genuine and respectful leadership she had facilitated and provided the space to allow change and growth in Aisling Centre’s work to happen.

“It has been a great honour for Aisling Centre and for all who work here, to have had Ann McDermott serve as Chairperson of the organisation and we look forward to her continuing to serve as a member of the Board of Directors.”



LIAM BLAKE PAINTING PRESENTATION

At Aisling Centre’s AGM on 28th October outgoing Chairperson Dr Ann McDermott presented a beautiful painting of Lough Erne, by the late Liam Blake, to the Centre.

As she made the presentation Ann spoke of Liam’s genius as an artist alongside his struggle with mental health and how it felt appropriate that one of his paintings should hang in Aisling Centre.

She went on to explain that she and her husband had bought the painting from an exhibition that was part of a collection held by his family at Devenish Gallery. As the ending of her term as Chairperson coincided with Aisling Centre’s 30th anniversary year it just ‘felt right’ that this painting should hang in Aisling Centre recognising both the genius of this local artist and the great work done by Aisling Centre in providing professional mental health services and challenging the stigma around poor mental health.

NEW APPOINTMENTS



At the AGM in October 2020 Alison Annan was appointed to the positon of Chairperson with Roberta Hamilton as vice-chair; both Alison and Roberta have had long association with Aisling Centre. Alison’s dating back to her days as a Youth Liaison Officer and Roberta’s as a teacher.

Both spoke of the support the Centre had always offered the community, particularly in the early days when there were very few local services. They described Aisling Centre as always having been a reputable service, with an open door to a warm, caring environment.

Accepting her nomination Alison said that “as a volunteer and a member of the local community it was a privilege to be elected to the positon of Chairperson”. Roberta said she felt both ‘honoured and privileged’ to have been elected to the position of Vice-Chairperson.

Both look forward to working together and with their fellow Directors as Aisling Centre moves into a new decade.

MARY’S RETIREMENT

After more than two decades of work with Aisling Centre Sr Mary Carroll has decided to retire. Through her work as a counsellor Mary has helped countless people through difficult times in their lives and indeed helped many find hope where they thought hope was gone. As these quotes from people she worked with show, Mary’s genuine interest, humility and care will be long remembered:

Mary is a wonderful person, anyone who has her for counselling is very lucky; she worked very hard with me.

Mary Carroll is a brilliant counsellor, without counselling life would have been a lot harder.

Mary has been excellent. Friendly, kind, understanding, unassuming, not judgemental.

Mary was brilliant for me she really listened and helped me get a lot of my stress and anxiety out.

Mary was brilliant, I feel so much better and can only praise Mary’s work, it took a right few weeks before I started to feel better in myself. Feel I can go on by myself now. Thank you Mary.

Mary has helped me a lot. I have kept my problems to myself for years and it was really good to talk, I never told my family.

Thanking Mary for her many years of service and life changing work at Aisling Centre Alison Annan, Chairperson, noted that it was because of the calibre of therapists like Mary that Aisling Centre was so highly regarded by the community. *“Mary you have given so much to others, now is your time, I wish you health and peace as you embark on the next chapter of your life.”*

Despite being from Monaghan, Mary is no stranger to the people of Fermanagh having initially worked as a teacher and later moving into community development. She earned herself a place in the hearts of the people in Enniskillen through the fantastic work she was involved in at 26 Yoan Road. Indeed it was in *“Yoan Road”* that the dream of Aisling Centre first took root.

Paying tribute to Mary’s work at Aisling Centre, Counselling Co-ordinator John Bennett felt that working as a counsellor allowed Mary to put her gifts and talents to the best use, allowing her care, empathy and concern for the individual to shine through.

Mary will be greatly missed by her friends and colleagues at Aisling Centre, she was a gentle but solid presence who wore her wisdom lightly, and over the years she welcomed new people to the team with kindness encouragement and support.

Bridie Sweeney, Centre co-ordinator described Mary as very unassuming and quick to brush off a compliment. Saying *“it is your kind heart and caring nature that will be remembered by all who worked with you in Aisling Centre and indeed by the many people you counselled over the years.”*

At a retirement party held via ZOOM Mary’s friends and colleagues lined up to pay tribute, thanking this special woman for the impact she had on their lives and sharing anecdotes and memories of good times and laughter.

Enjoy your well-deserved retirement Mary.



Meet The Team





PATRON
Adrian Dunbar

HONORARY MEMBER
Sr Edel Bannon

BOARD OF DIRECTORS
Alison Annan - Chairperson
Roberta Hamilton - Vice-Chairperson
Marshall Coalter – Secretary
Neville Armstrong - Treasurer

DIRECTORS
Ann McDermott
Aideen McGinley
Iain Kennedy

DIRECTORS JOINING MAY 2021
Deirdre Kane
Grainne Scott
Richard Smith

MANAGEMENT TEAM
Bridie Sweeney Centre Co-ordinator
John Bennett Clinical Co-ordinator
Patricia Kelly Admin/Facilitates Manager

CLINICAL TEAM
Clare Love
Edel McGuiness
Sharon Fitzpatrick

SESSIONAL PSYCHOTHERAPISTS
Ann Farrell
Mary Carroll – retired March 21
Brenda Wynne-McKervey
Helen Murphy
Holly Reid
Karen Whaley
Nicholas May
Nuala McGovern
Fiona McCaughey
Cahir Maguire
Rosemary Cupples
Patricia McGovern

CLINICAL PLACEMENTS
Denise Crudden
Rosa Furey

ADMINISTRATION TEAM
Fiona Beatty
Fionnuala Curran
Jimmy Britton
Joan Thompson
Marie Greene

ADMIN VOLUNTEERS
Bronagh Reilly
Margaret Corrigan
Rita Murphy

SESSIONAL CT
Sheila Johnston
Siobhan Conlon
Shauna McMorrow

CLEANING
Kinga Amtomzak (Prestige Cleaning)

We would also like to acknowledge the role of our friends and volunteers, too many to mention individually, who play an invaluable role in supporting Aisling Centre through a range of activities including awareness raising and fund raising.















Aisling
centre
Hope Healing Growth

Aisling Centre
37, Darling Street, Enniskillen
Co Fermanagh, BT74 7DP

Telephone: 028 66 325811
Email: info@theaislingcentre.com

www.theaislingcentre.com

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